QUICK GUIDE

CLIPPED WAVEFORM

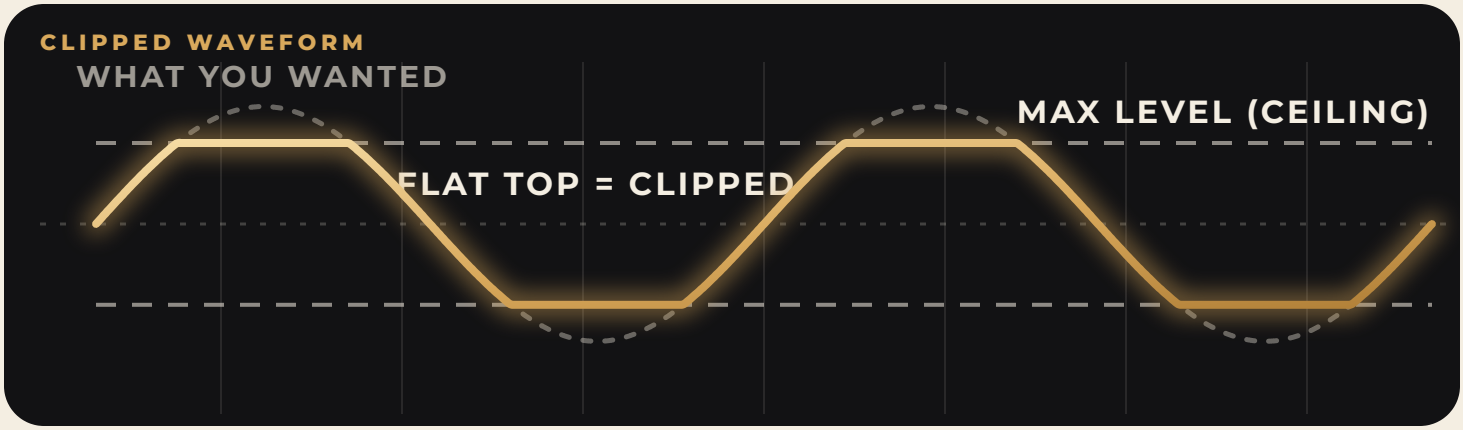
What it is, how to spot it and what to do with it.

WHAT IT IS

Clipping happens when a signal is pushed past the maximum level a system can handle. The peaks get cut flat, which adds harsh distortion.

HOW IT SOUNDS

Harsh, fizzy and crunchy. Loud, but tiring to listen to.



01

FLAT TOPS AND BOTTOMS

The peaks hit a ceiling and stop.

02

HARSH, FIZZY SOUND

Distortion adds harmonics that weren't in the music.

03

RED MEANS STOP

Hot meters and constant red lights are the warning.

DO THIS TONIGHT

Keep every meter out of the red. Fix loudness at the amp.

- [ ] Set each channel gain so peaks stay out of the red.
- [ ] Keep the master meter out of the red too.
- [ ] Need more volume? Turn up the system, not the signal.



PRACTICE & CHECK

CLIPPED WAVEFORM: YOUR TURN

WHERE YOU'LL MEET IT AS A DJ

- Master meters sitting in the red.
- Over-gained tracks and channels.
- Big EQ boosts that push a channel over the limit.

QUICK CHECK

1. What does a clipped waveform look like?

2. Can you fix clipping cleanly afterwards?

3. How do you avoid it?

Answer key: 1) Flat tops and bottoms. 2) Not cleanly. Prevent it at the source. 3) Leave headroom. Keep meters out of the red.

REMEMBER

Leave headroom. Loud should still be clean.

YOUR NOTES

UP NEXT Beat Waveform

